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How to Design a Game Laboratory to Study Games: Theory and Case Study of a Playful Third Space

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ABSTRACT:
Multidisciplinary game studies is a uniquely challenging type of academia to implement, for a variety of ideological and practical reasons. Diverse forms of research are widely seen as desirable with clear benefits but also challenges for the research community. Contemporary work has called for more techniques to overcome these challenges and reap the benefits. This paper proposes a promising technique that is understudied – playful third spaces in universities where multidisciplinary education and research may be conducted. This text proposes this tool, through the lens of pluralist game studies, and discusses a case study for a multidisciplinary playful third space that encourages games research and pedagogy. Three components of this space and how it influences research projects hosted will be explained for their interdisciplinary benefits: playful infrastructure, comfort-design, public-private availability. In summary, playful third spaces are a promising multidisciplinary intersectional tool for future pluralistic game studies laboratories and research groups.

KEY WORDS:
game laboratories, playful third spaces, pluralist game studies, third space.

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Introduction

Since its inception, game studies have held great hope and promise for being a *multidisciplinary* (Mäyrä, 2008) field. Inside this promise was the belief by scholars that applying a diverse set of research approaches improves our understanding of games. As Consalvo (2012) argued, "no one discipline or field should (or can) have control over game research or theorization, and the study of games is enriched by multiple paths of inquiry" (p. 8). The approach of openness to different fields of inquiry has seen some powerful benefits, enabling new theoretical developments to terms like game (Stenros, 2017) or the playful relevance of parties (Masek & Stenros, 2024), to even entirely novel approaches to games such as queer game studies (see Ruberg et al., 2017).

There are however major disagreements about how to practically coordinate a diverse group of researchers on the topic of games-related phenomena. Some scholars argue game studies should unite under a new codified discipline (Malazita et al., 2024) whereas others have argued each scholar should have a "home discipline", which they then bring into the cross-disciplinary game studies spaces (Consalvo, 2012). Several texts harshly criticize the current state of interdisciplinary game studies calling it a pyrrhic victory (Deterding, 2017), reducing diverse voices (Malazita et al., 2024), or being in need of changing its identity to "play studies" (Gekker, 2021, p. 79) or "game design studies" (Deterding, 2017 p. 534). Criticisms range from disciplinary systems giving scholars better career rewards than multidisciplinary spaces (Deterding, 2017), to theoretical views that without active tools, game researchers will just talk over other scholars with diverse viewpoints (Williams, 2005). In this way, there is a dual situation in game studies, where scholars generally agree on the goal of diverse approaches to games but disagree on the

methods of how to reach it. This frames the sticky question of this research project: How do we practically support the valuable diversity of research on games, while enabling these diverse scholars to interact with each other as a community of practice?

This work offers a solution by analyzing a research tool that has practically brought together diverse scholars and students with a singular institutional investment – *playful third spaces*. This text unpacks the idea of playful third spaces and their history, discusses a larger framing ideology of pluralist game studies, and unpacks a case study of one such space being used for diverse research on games and play at a mid-sized university in Finland. In conclusion, specific essential criteria for how to set up such a space to support diverse scholarship with games will be presented for future games researchers.

Theoretical Framework

The study builds upon the ideological concept of *pluralist games studies* (Masek, 2025). This approach seeks to reinforce past discourses on multidisciplinary game studies, which have often focused on theoretical discussions of, for example, diversity of methods that study games (Lankoski & Björk, 2015) with additional discourse on practical institutional tools to support multidisciplinarity. It asks meta-institutional questions on how to make diverse, intersectional, scholarly conversations institutionally accessible and beneficial for those doing it? In order to contextualize the current contribution, the text will discuss the problem that pluralist game studies aims to solve. It will explore past solutions and why they are probably insufficient, and then it will build on this approach to propose a new technique – playful third spaces.

As previously mentioned, there are major disagreements about how game studies should be organized as a research community. Most commonly, scholars have argued for one of two major ideologies present in game studies: *factionalist* game studies, and *unified disciplinary* game studies (Masek, 2025). Factionalist game studies as typified by Consalvo (2012) argues that game studies scholars should and do each have a "home discipline". Then cross-disciplinary scholarly spaces studying games will bring together these diverse scholars. In contrast, *unified disciplinary* game studies, as typified by Malazita et al. (2024) argues that this is insufficient and that game studies needs to enable deeper conversations between diverse members. They propose that game studies should be a singular and new discipline typified by "constructive friction". This is an important question as ideologies about discipline alter the way academics embody teaching and research in practice (Fanghanel, 2009).

A newly proposed solution, termed pluralist game studies (Masek, 2025), asserts that both factionalist and unitary ideologies are valuable but flawed at the same time. Pluralist game studies argues that game studies needs to develop tools for scholars to be trained in "home disciplines", including any new disciplinary game studies while also having systems for cross-disciplinary contact to enable novel approaches. It argues that if we do not normalize direct contact with different disciplines game scholars will always be, de facto, unprepared to interact with contrasting disciplines to their own.

The techniques proposed are categorized as *anti-disciplinary*, *anti-qualification*, and *anti-exclusionary* space practices. Anti-disciplinary tools are systemic practices that enable scholars with differing research methods to directly interact with each other. Anti-qualification spaces are specific zones where individuals with different career-phases are working together, performing similar tasks rather than e.g. "doctoral consortiums". Anti-exclusionary practices involve reducing monetary barriers to entry for career pursuit

in academia. These tools work in different ways to mix different disciplinary thinking methods and scholars with differing career backgrounds. In mixing these things explicitly, those who are less disciplinarily connected can reap more status rewards, and scholars will naturally be exposed to more diverse scholarship (Masek, 2025).

Whereas Masek (2025) focuses on publication venues, journals and conferences, there is another key element of academia that can be analysed and possibly made more sustainably diverse through the lens of pluralist game studies: research labs. How to practically structure diverse games research contends with practical pressures of labour, capital, and research institutions. The way groups of researchers organize their work effects the type and quantity of work they produce (Carayol & Matt, 2004), which Wenger (2011) calls a community of practice or a research laboratory. Guidelines for setting up effective research communities and labs exist in several disciplines such as computational biology (Kaiser, 2024), political science (Weinschenk, 2021), and pedagogy (Sanchez et al., 2022). In game research, there is only a limited set of publications on what tools may be beneficial for setting up an effective game studies research laboratory. This is a major gap, as games researchers face a widely agreed upon unique challenge related to the degree of research diversity that their colleagues may practice (Klabbers, 2018).

This text argues that a pluralist approach to a game studies research lab has been taken before, and has shown value through the creation of playful third spaces that house games research. Third spaces are post-colonial theory, generally based on thinking of Bhabha's (2012) location of culture. It builds on the work of Turner (1992), to understand how cultural meanings can be reinterpreted, transitioned, or resignified. As Kalua (2009) described, it

> is not an overdetermined space but one loaded with ambiguity; it represents an act of unleashing that post-dialectical moment when people reject structures and hegemonies and occupy any one of the heterogeneous spaces where they negotiate narratives of their existences as well as of particular spaces of meanings and different identities. (Kalua, 2009, p. 25)

In this way, third spaces, will (in this text) refer to spaces that are intentionally open to the ambiguous meanings that are required when a non-hegemonic space is being sought. This philosophical concept has practical value in a variety of ways having been used to understand how sporting associations (Ruddock, 2005) and bars (Law, 2013) are spaces of civic engagement. This idea has some similarities with third places (Oldenburg, 1997), which are defined as being neither home nor workplaces. Third space theory has been applied to certain types of work environments, especially in academia as "a way of exploring groups of staff in higher education who do not fit conventional binary descriptors such as those enshrined in 'academic' or 'non-academic' employment categories" (Whitchurch, 2015, p. 1). They have also been studied for how they increase student retention and sense of belonging (Hughes et al., 2021), as a tool for embodied critical learning (Gutiérrez, 2008), and as a framework for transdisciplinary research in general (Veles & Danaher, 2024). In this way, third space theory seems promising for the pluralist approach to game studies as it already seems oriented towards transgressing conventional boundaries of hegemonic control, in this case, often based on disciplinary practices. The current work will propose playful third spaces as a novel version of this kind of space, oriented specifically to game studies.

Playful third spaces are thus typified by the ideological premise of the non-determinism and openness of third spaces, with a focus on supporting the analysis of playful behaviour writ large. Playful behaviours may include the playing of traditional video games, puzzles in the space, chatting with friends, while not disallowing working or sleeping in the space. In alignment with Third Spaces bringing together people with differing identities, they also can host talks with a variety of playful experts, game designers, scholars etc.

Playful third spaces have been applied previously in promising ways to the nearby context of games development and design. Past third spaces have been studied for how they integrate games and game expertise specifically. The Oulu Game Lab in Finland uses "providing re-skilling and re-education opportunities for unemployed ICT professionals and equipping them with business and employment bonds with regional game industry companies" (Pokidina et al., 2023, p. 40). This program had a pedagogical program, split into two sections - LEAD and LAB sections - which focused on re-educating Information and Communication Technology professionals on how to make digital games, and then on how to pitch or acquire funding for their digital game companies. This space demonstrates how these spaces can be effective ways to mix different stakeholders, such as industry and academia.

The playful by design initiative (Pintar & Bievenue, 2024), in contrast, set up an interdisciplinary community for designers and educators of games. This cross-campus initiative at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign aimed to bring game design faculty into closer contact with game studies faculty through workshops, symposiums, courses and an active third space. It resulted in the development of a master's degree and a set of notes about how to mix disciplinarity, local faculty, and status hierarchies to better develop more interdisciplinary game studies.

While the above two projects show great promise, they also focus on a different element of games than the current text. Both analyse spaces for creating games and enabling contact between industry game designers, design academics, and students. Pintar and Bievenue (2024) discuss how their project had goals for supporting interdisciplinary research, including a symposium for example, but the discussion of research is brief. This is not a criticism, so much as a sign that it is valuable to discuss these spaces specifically for their practical and diverse research uses. This paper will analyse one such third space conducting multidisciplinary games research at Tampere University in Finland, called Oasis. This lab has operated for ten years, has been utilized for a variety of game research projects and novel pedagogical programs on research. In performing these functions, several key elements of this space are important for its sustainable ability to contribute to diverse scholarly thinking on games.

Methodology

To best understand how a public playful third space can be designed, a case study of one such space will be analysed. Case studies are a subset of field research that investigates a phenomenon as it occurs with a detailed analysis, concluding with a bottom-up theoretical understanding. In this way, the text aims to support two forms of knowledge, a "comprehensive understanding of the event under study but at the same time to develop more general theoretical statements about regularities in the observed phenomena" (Fidel, 1984, p. 274). The current work composes its argument on two forms of data: longitudinal observation by one recent responsible runner in the space and a review of past studies published using the space.

The authors of this text are the primary organizer of the research group within the space, and two research assistants who participated in the program. In this way, their analysis of the space comes with both strengths and biases. On the one hand, they have intimate awareness of practically important elements of several studies conducted in the space. On the other hand, their views are subjective in nature as is common in case study research.

Case studies are a valuable, yet limited, method of research. Notably, there are limits to how generalizable their claims can be. In this way, if one undertook a larger study comparing multiple such spaces, new and important findings would likely appear. As there are only a few such spaces that exist, we view the current work as an important contribution towards a larger understanding. To support the validity of the findings of this work, each interpretation will be based on multiple kinds of evidence from different studies conducted in the space, as recommended by Diesing (2017). Limitations of the space will also be unpacked in the hopes of providing value for future scholars interested in implementing the framework presented.

Case Study: Oasis

In 2014, Tampere University opened Oasis, which was intentionally designed to be a playful space in the university with a large variety of ways it could be used, including comfortable seating, bright colours, open access to digital games on several consoles, and a variety of changing interactive toys, puzzles etc. (Kultima et al., 2014). Oasis was furthermore designed as a "social learning and research space" (Kultima et al., 2014, p. 10). It has four publicly available computers, gaming consoles, projectors, other playful objects, such as Lego, and a game focused multimedia library. The space is open access during the day and can be reserved for private events during the evenings. Oasis operates these activities through a 20-40-person student group called the "Keymaster group". This group is an accredited course which is available for 1.5 credits and is responsible for "facilitating and organizing events, taking care of technology and the game and book libraries, and supporting research conducted in the space" ("OASIS key masters", n.d., para. 1). This is broken down into a variety of different tasks that Oasis maintains, such as upkeeping the digital game collection/interfaces, extending and maintaining the game-research library, running and managing public/private events, often five nights a week, and finally pursuing and conducting research.

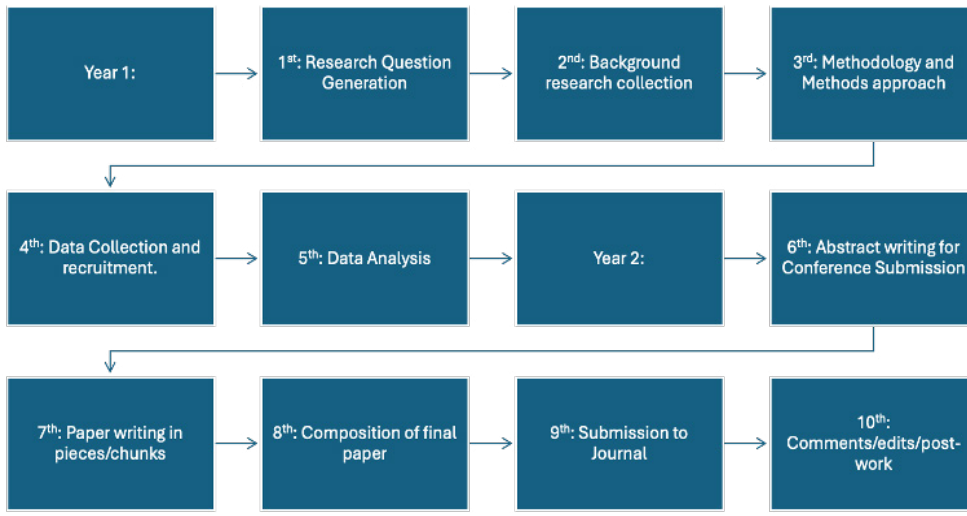
Oasis was also organized for a research project investigating "the experience of playfulness and the incentives and thresholds of adult play at the workplace" and "comprised three playful experiments involving staff members" (Nummenmaa, Savolainen & Kultima, 2015, p. 5). These three research projects were an interactive *playful art installation* (Kultima et al., 2016), a gamified intervention to increase workplace social connection (Nummenmaa, Kultima, et al., 2015), and a series of workshops on conceptions of play in the workplace (Nummenmaa, Savolainen & Kultima, 2015). It has also been reported on in a variety of manners. It hosted a hybrid play seminar (Paavilainen et al., 2018) and a study on the effects of playful seating on work meetings (Nummenmaa, Tyni, et al., 2015). It has also been discussed in past texts as an example of a hybrid university environmental design (Ninnemann et al., 2020) and playful architecture (Poutanen, 2018). Oasis has also been studied for how it, as a coworking space, is inhabited by students as regards their behaviour and resulting wellbeing (Masek et al., 2024). Finally, it has been used to bring strangers together to study how Nintendo Party Games may facilitate social connection (based on the own unpublished research).

In this way, Oasis has hosted a diversity of disciplinary types of research. Oasis has housed playful interactive art installations in such a way that it is easier to record participant involvement and may increase their playful participation (Kultima et al., 2016; Nummenmaa, Tyni, et al., 2015). Oasis has also been used as host location for interventions (Paavilainen et al., 2018; Nummenmaa, Kultima, et al., 2015; Nummenmaa,

Tyni, et al., 2015; Masek et al., 2025). Finally, Oasis has been studied for its design, and the ways that design may affect its users in their normative behaviours (Kultima et al., 2014; Masek et al., 2024). In this way, we can see how the space has been used for a variety of different research goals, embodying the ambiguity of third space theory and anti-disciplinary practices of pluralist game studies. Whereas these past reports are useful in their own rights, the space has not yet been analysed for how its design directly enables a diversity of research forms. In addition to these research goals, Oasis also teaches students how to conduct diverse research in a way that embodies the anti-qualification recommendations of pluralist game studies.

Pedagogical use of Oasis

Oasis is a living lab that involves student-researchers in praxis-based education for conducting games research. Praxis-based education is a larger pedagogical concept applied by several intellectual traditions for integrating direct experience with theoretical knowledge. This concept has Aristotelian roots (Papastephanou, 2013), later development by Bourdieu (1977), and more recent applications (Ritchie, 2023). In this case, praxis refers to both students' learning theoretical knowledge about research projects, methods, and writing, while simultaneously directly engaging in a research project themselves. Of note, this research project has a target learning outcome of enabling independent researcher thinking, which is usually seen as a doctoral level research goal (Gardner, 2008). This rather difficult learning target is paired with the reality that it is a pass/fail participation-oriented class. The pedagogical aim is to thus construct a strongly facilitated learning community (Pyhältö et al., 2009) for the students, where through this facilitated research group of students they learn how collaborative group research functions.



Picture 1: The 2-year cycle of Oasis Research Group

Source: own processing

Oasis Research Group is the resulting praxis-based pedagogical researcher group. It is a 2-year research cycle pedagogical group (Picture 1), where, predominantly master's students, go through the process of designing, implementing, writing, and publishing an

academic research project, with the assistance of a PhD level facilitator. The open ability for master's students to directly guide and influence a research project with a doctoral-level researcher is a representation of the pluralist technique of anti-qualification or "'gradient spaces', where the career stage of a scholar does not define the access they have to participate in the space" (Masek, 2025, p. 2). In this way, Oasis represents not only a research-oriented space, but a pedagogical space for games research. Beyond the goals of this kind of space, there is also a value behind discussing the design choices that enable this kind of goal to be successful.

This pedagogical program has run for three years, with three research studies implemented. These three datasets have resulted in the following publications: two extended abstracts (Masek et al., 2024; Masek et al., 2025), one accepted conference paper (Masek et al., 2026), one journal article currently under review (TBA) and the current text. In total eleven students have participated in the program and received publication credits in top venues in the field of Game Studies.

Designing a Third Space for Games Research

There are three critical design choices for how Oasis has influenced the research projects conducted inside it: 1.) Oasis is a space which houses *playful infrastructure* including games, puzzles, etc.; 2.) Oasis is a *comfortable space*, both socially and physically, with an accessible location, welcoming community, and furniture that can rested on.; 3.) Oasis is a publicly available yet privately bookable space. This text will explore these three features of Oasis, how they have affected the diverse studies conducted in the space and how they may be used as design recommendations for scholars or departments interested in creating their own public games-research spaces.

a) Playful infrastructure: Games, puzzles, toys, technology

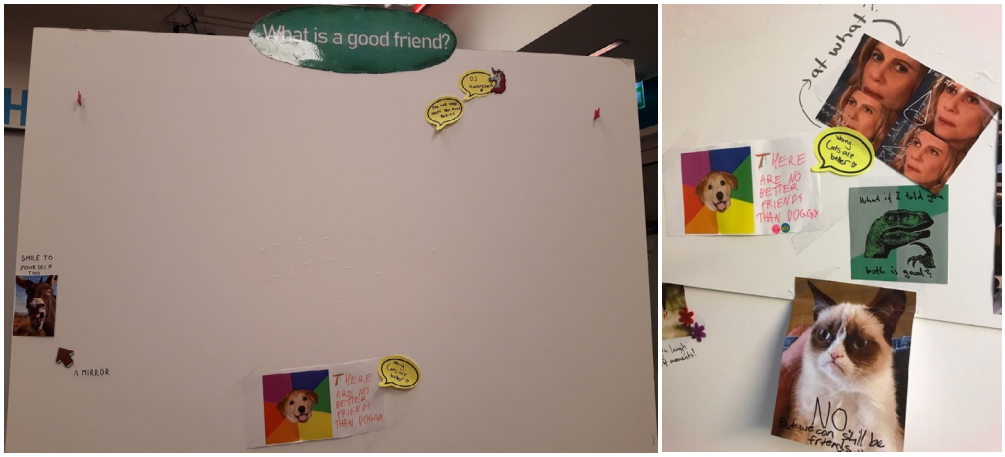
The first category for how the design of Oasis impacts studies within the space is playful infrastructure. Playful infrastructure refers to investments that enable play within the space that might be difficult for individuals to access on their own. This might refer to VR headsets, projectors, consoles or other expensive playful technologies. It also might refer to decorative Hama beads or small puzzles that are readily available in the public space and would be some level of difficult for an individual to bring regularly on their own to a university. This infrastructure is helpful for a game-studying space for two reasons: one studying how students emergently use such playful options and their effects, and secondly, this infrastructure enables researchers to conduct experiments requiring such technology, as it is pre-purchased and accessible. The presence of playful infrastructure also might act as a cognitive priming, enabling students to more easily engage playfully with public participation events/studies/cultural probes. This priming effect is at least partially supported by users of Oasis reporting more perceived playfulness than in other similarly located co-working spaces that did not intend playful design (Masek et al., 2024).

Oasis is in part defined by its playful infrastructure and a team of student volunteers who ensure that those games, puzzles etc are working and accessible (Kultima et al., 2014). Oasis is seen in its design as inviting participants to engage in playful activities in addition to work (Kultima et al., 2018). These playful offers have been studied as affecting the types of behaviour that users show emergently while in Oasis (Masek et al., 2024).

Masek et al. (2024) found that participants saw themselves as regularly engaged in using this playful infrastructure e.g. playing on the game consoles. Playful infrastructure, in this way, opens a door for the naturalistic observation (Angrosino, 2016) of play behaviours. Without Oasis' investment in an open access space, these types of observations would not be possible in the same way.

Several past research projects also utilized playful infrastructure for intervention studies. Masek et al. (2025) brought together strangers to play Nintendo games on a Nintendo Switch. This console is an example of an infrastructural investment that was made easier by the public game space already having it. An ongoing study similarly has used VR headsets to study user experiences. In another way, this playful infrastructure can take less traditional forms, such as designed playful seating for the space (Numenmaa, Tyni, et al., 2015).

This playful infrastructure also supports public interactive arts research projects by cognitively priming (Schacter et al., 2004) participants for playful behaviour. Students immersed in a space they find playful may make them more playfully engaged in general. There have been several such interactive research projects in Oasis (Kultima et al., 2016). For example, in winter 2020, *Mental Health: The Game* was a public interactive piece intended as a form of cultural probe (Gaver et al., 1999) and artistic provocation (Hannula et al., 2014). Students were asked to make a graffiti wall of memes or other such playful responses "as launching pads, as tools" (Hannula et al., 2014, p. 17), answering serious mental health questions. For instance, an active discourse between memes answering the question: "What is a good friend?" The first text was "There are no better friends than dogs", followed by the response "Wrong: Cats are Better". The memes then continue in conversation clockwise (Picture 2). While, due to the Covid-19 pandemic, this research never materialised into a publication, it still represents an artistic methodology, ideology, and pedagogy that is uniquely facilitated in a living lab and play space.



Picture 2: Example of a Graffiti wall with some meme responses
Source: own processing

It is very possible that in a less playful space, the answers gathered would be less playful. Other studies in Oasis benefited from a cognitive priming of playfulness, such as the interactive exhibit There Are No Rules, which aimed to be an "invitation to play" (Kultima et al., 2016, p. 404) with a large pool of coloured dice. This phrase represents a general view that by having many play affordances available, people in the space may well

be generally invited to occupy the space playfully. This playful infrastructure being used for such different disciplinary approaches to game studies also represents how to implement the value of anti-disciplinarity in pluralist game studies. To further support such a goal, authors recommend intentionally mixing scholars with different backgrounds and conducting studies with different methods, as much as possible, in curating research projects within the space. Brought together, we can see a valuable component of the design of Oasis and how it affects specific approaches to studying games/play.

Summary: Access to video games, toys, puzzles and other playful objects can enable a variety of research. It can result in students naturally using such playful options, which can be studied. The infrastructure can be used for controlled studies. Finally, it may act as cognitive priming for cultural probes/artistic provocations, encouraging playful responses from those inhabiting the space.

b) Comfort-design: Soft furniture, open social environment, non-stressful and low threshold

Another important design feature of Oasis that is helpful for any future group wanting to create a game-studying third place is designed comfort. This comfort is both physical, such as having mixed comfortable seating, chairs, bean bags, etc., and also a socially designed sense of comfort. Oasis's social comfort is intentionally supported by its organizers with public signs describing it for users as "open for everybody!" ("OASIS is a social", n.d., para. 1). This sense of comfort is useful for conducting a variety of studies, as students occupy the space in restful ways and then choose to participate in studies or other activities. Comfort is thus also important for enabling more casual participation between users of the space for games research and events, etc.

Comfort, both physically and socially, is a foundational design goal in Oasis. In its formal design report, one of the key requests by students when the space was built was "a simple request from all three groups is to have more comfortable sofas to sit while waiting for the next lecture or discussing with peers" (Kultima et al., 2014, p. 62). This type of physical comfort is embodied in the space by a mixture of chairs, tables, but also by bean bags and couches. The lighting of the space also offers different levels that may enable more restful behaviours/control over the visual comfort in the space.

Social comfort is also a critical value of the space, as can be seen in the design reports' description that "Oasis is designed as an open, social environment. Oasis encourages open culture, informal learning and casual information sharing" (Kultima et al., 2014, p. 8). This type of social comfort is enacted in Oasis in part by its Keymaster program. The Keymasters are a social group in Oasis who run the space as a course for credits at the university. They often number 20-40 students and create a wide variety of people who are experts in the space. These student-keymasters have an explicit goal of being welcoming to any users in the space, and enable a general level of relaxation in the space. If anyone has a problem there, there is a high chance that a keymaster is in the room and can help. This supportive social community is possibly one of the most critical design components for this kind of space to be sustainable.

The comfort in the space is important for a number of studies and research pursuits that have happened in Oasis. The naturalistic study of Oasis users found that one of the primary activities that students had in it was resting (Masek et al., 2024). Artistic provocations benefit from having casual comfortable users watching for a time and participating partially. In one artistic provocation in the space, the most common way participants interacted with it was called "Fiddling: activity that is noncommittal in nature and lacks a definite goal or purpose; playing around with the dice; can be secondary to some other simultaneous activity (e.g. done while talking to someone)" (Kultima et al., 2016, p. 406).

One can imagine how this noncommittal interaction not only sometimes escalates in to more full participation, but also normalizes interacting with the playful piece. In addition, a variety of research talks, events, etc. have benefited from users in the space resting inside it, and then accidentally joining a research event. This represents the general goal of many mixed-use coworking spaces, called informal or accidental learning (Emelo, 2012). In addition, these resting individuals were also recruited from for intervention studies that occurred in Oasis (Masek et al., 2025). This design tenet can also be seen as the experiential requirement for anti-exclusionary practice in pluralist game studies (Masek et al., 2025). In order to further support implementation of that goal, the authors would recommend explicitly advertising an open-use policy and avoid prescribing how users are supposed to occupy the space. Brought together, we can see a valuable component of the design of Oasis and how it affects specific approaches to studying games/play.

Summary: Creating a space that is comfortable to rest in is valuable for games research. This social and physical comfort enables more casual participation in all forms of research, such as observing an artistic provocation, and accidentally learning or being given more opportunities to participate further.

c) Publicly known but privately usable

The final critical component of Oasis as a scientifically active third space is its mixed usability as both a public and private space. It is generally public and a glass room, so the space is visible for students/staff walking through a major central hub of the university. In this way, users know clearly where it is and often spend time there. In contrast, the space is also lockable, bookable and can be used, in private, for specific research purposes, especially at times that are not its normal opening hours. This is useful in a few ways, firstly recruiting individuals for a variety of studies from the public users. In addition, studies that occur in Oasis are uniquely benefited by participants having a clear sense of where the study would be and decreasing the stress associated with joining.

Oasis has been used in past studies in both functions, both public and private. Publicly, the space has been observed for natural play behaviours by university students (Masek et al., 2024), and also hosted specific public playful provocations which public users were invited to engage in (Kultima et al., 2016). Oasis has also been used as a positivist-controlled environment (Park et al., 2020) where a singular, repeatable event can occur with the minimization of bias, distraction, or outside influence (e.g. Masek et al., 2025; Nummenmaa, Tyni, et al., 2015).

In some studies, participants were also recruited through Oasis (Masek et al., 2025), and were thus probably more comfortable with joining a research project due to their familiarity with the space. While the participant sample is biased by the self-selection of participants to those who would occupy Oasis and play games and by the space itself being playful rather than neutral, this bias is also a bit of an opportunity to study specific social groups who are interested in games. Brought together we can see a valuable component of the design of Oasis and how it affects specific approaches to studying games/play.

Summary: Having a publicly available space, in a central and visually obvious part of the University, enables emergent behaviours by users to occupy the space. These users can also be recruited from for future studies. In addition, having the ability to turn the space into a private one is useful, especially for controlled interventions.

Discussion

Taken together, specific components of multi-use games research and pedagogy third spaces are critical for implementing a diverse research group on games. Firstly, playful infrastructure, including game consoles, VR headsets, puzzles etc. have two valuable research uses. Scholars who wish to study how people experience these games/play acts can use them for their own interventions. Secondly, by leaving these systems publicly accessibly, users of the space itself will exhibit play behaviours with those objects. This natural play behaviour will have interesting particularities to it, and can be studied for its own sake and for its consequences on those individuals. While not in the above studies, this kind of access to games can enable scholars, as well as doctoral or master's students access to those games/game systems that they may be unable to afford themselves. Secondly, a comfortable space enables individuals to rest, observe studies, possibly increasing later playful engagement. Thirdly, a publicly known but privately controllable location was essential, both for enabling users to come and use the space, but also for it to be a site easily known for intervention-use:

- *Playful Infrastructure:* Games, play objects, monitors, projectors.
- *Comfort-design:* Multiple seating/resting/laying seats, supportive social culture.
- *Public/private:* "In the middle" of university spaces, a glass-wall showing its location, advertisement, public use. Also, closeable and bookable for private purposes.

As the variety of methods present in the case studies demonstrates, Oasis is notably flexible in its research affordances. It can be used as an open-access space priming audiences to engage in playful imaginaries, a home for naturalistic research of young adult play behaviour, and as a controlled location for a game-based intervention. Each of the above studies represents different approaches to research both in method and key components of ideology. Oasis also has additional potential for appropriation by scholars from a variety of even more diverse backgrounds.

This space has several interesting characteristics through the lens of pluralist game studies. Its playful infrastructure has supported contrasting disciplinary methods, from arts to design to controlled intervention. The users of the space are explicitly welcomed in a free, non-pre-defined manner, supporting anti-exclusionary practice. Finally, the research group itself brings together scholars at different phases of their research career with similar goals, supporting a gradient-space between scholastic levels.

Multi-use game spaces can accommodate a broad range of research. It can be used to study both physical and digital games in both natural or guided settings. In this way, they offer an effective multi-tool for a game lab, accommodating diverse researchers with varying research goals, or conceptions of research. This value is present on every stage of the research maturation process, from student pedagogy to researcher projects.

The lens of pluralist game studies is a valuable way to unpack the value of such a space in a university. Different disciplinary approaches to games have been studied in Oasis, embodying the desire to bring together.

Limitations

While this kind of open access play space has many promising components for hosting and facilitating games research and education, it has several limitations as well. This

type of space requires curation and support to produce relevant research. In addition, some aspects of a multi-use space conflict directly with each other. Most notably, loud play behaviours, such as groups playing popular video games, may disrupt those attempting to use it as an academic workspace. These tensions are not necessarily 'flaws' of the space but rather tensions that may be beneficial or problematic.

It seems to be a pragmatic reality that play/playfulness in a multi-use space is often disruptive to other behaviours including 'rest' and 'work'. While this may lead certain readers to believe that multi-use spaces are therefore not worth investing in, a contrasting point should be highlighted. To achieve an open-access inclusive space, possible conflicts between diverse users must be allowed. The author sees this as *flexibility* and *inclusion* conflicting with certain forms of *comfort*. The exact way to navigate these conflicts is not simple, as comfort is one of the key design elements for a successful space. These conflicts are probably worthwhile, though as pluralism argues, at least some conflict is worth the benefits of diversity (Masek, 2025).

Another concern to discuss is whether a mixed-use space, especially mixing work and play as an intention for a space is unethical (e.g. Abend et al., 2021). There can be concerns of exploitation, especially if the playful space is set up by an employer to encourage higher levels of labour. This is usually an off-topic criticism for many free to use multi-use game spaces, as the space does not leverage playfulness to induce additional labour for itself. However, this concern has come up in several academic conferences, and it is an important topic for designing these spaces.

This paper wishes to reframe this question. Rather than viewing the space as possibly nefariously "mixing" work and play, this text would encourage the reader to see it in the opposite way - some users may wish to work in publicly available spaces and others may wish to play in them, and it is important to respect these diverse users. Inclusive multi-use spaces are thus more flexible than a more tightly controlled space. There are spaces at universities that prioritize single uses, such as one such room just down the hall from Oasis. This room is intended exclusively for game researchers to play a set of games that are under lock and key. This space also lies empty on most days, and if it is used, it is used by at most a handful of people. Oasis on the other hand, which is maybe twice the size, regularly houses many more users, thus presenting a different type of benefit for researcher and student communities.

There are important design choices though that can be made to avoid potential fears around mixing work and play. Game spaces should put in effort to ensure the engaging-playful atmosphere of a multi-use space does not result in a sense of pressure to overwork. One such effective design choice is intentionally creating the opportunity to rest in the space: for example, by filling it with sleep able bean bags. Another choice that might help this is not trying to place 'motivational' play posters/designs in the space. Whereas a traditional coworking space may have a variety of inspirational-engaging slogans to make work seem more playful, we encourage these spaces to be playful *not* on the topic of work, while also enabling students to choose to work in them if they so wish. This goal also aligns with general workplace wellbeing studies that argue that work, play, and rest form an important trifecta of behaviour for resilience (McMurtie & Crane, 2020).

These conflicts are an expected result of a pluralist approach to game studies. This larger theory already assumes there will be conflict between people with differing views. In a pluralist framework this seems like a *good* sign that there is a successful mixing of differing views. It is valuable to confront at least some conflicts for the goal of diversity.

Another critical limitation and consideration for such a space is the resource investment required for it. The above program was embedded inside of a long-established games research lab, with a 20-40-person undergraduate student volunteer network

helping it function. These student volunteers receive credits for supporting the space, so it is possible that that reward may be replicable in other institutions. There are sizable up-front costs for purchasing the relevant infrastructure needed for the lab, but this is also probably true of most scientific laboratory set ups. In addition, the pedagogical and research endeavour was run by a PhD-volunteer, with no substantial monetary compensation. This system, while cost effective for the lab, at under 1,000 euro paid for the three-year implementation, is not likely to be long-term sustainable. Indeed, after the third year of operation this program has entered hiatus, as no funding was obtained to continue it, and there were no leading volunteers for an unpaid fourth project. In this way, if an institution wished for such a lab to be sustainable, they would probably need a funded individual supporting its operation, as is realistically required of all professional research institutions. This kind of lab however, still creates a fertile territory for supporting a PhD-level or post-doctoral research project, internally or externally funded, leveraging the benefits of the space. In some ways, the intentional disciplinary openness is an economic benefit for such a space, as fixed term researchers can be invited to mould their project to fit their background.

Conclusion

This work describes the theoretical value behind public-access playful third spaces for games pedagogy and research. It does this by clarifying the concept, expanding on past studies looking at this kind of space for game design, and unpacking a case study at a mid-sized Finnish University. In this case study, three critical features were analysed as critically influential for the research and pedagogical projects housed there. These projects come from a wide methodological background, from artistic, to observational, to intervention studies, which represents critical value for contemporary game-studies research centres aiming to be pluralistic. As game studies is and continues to be interdisciplinary, it will benefit from more tools on how to implement the difficulty of multiple disciplines working with each other. Future research groups, labs, schools, or institutions may benefit from creating publicly accessible, yet privately controllable, comfortable locations that also house playful infrastructure.

This work aims to add clarity to a sticky question in game studies: How do we practically support the valuable diversity of research on games, while enabling these diverse scholars to interact with each other as a community of practice? It uses the theoretical tenets of pluralist game studies (Masek, 2025), and describes how a playful third space can practically support diverse research through this ideology. This case study has limits, and has not solved the problems of multidisciplinarity, especially criticisms that narrower disciplinary work tends to receive higher economic rewards (Deterding, 2017). Despite these limits, it is still a valuable tool, ideology, and pedagogical approach for future game studies research organizers to consider.

These spaces have unique characteristics that are valuable for conducting a variety of games research studies: Firstly, participants may be primed for playful attitudes increasing their willingness to engage with cultural probes and artistic provocations. Second, playful spaces are naturally occupied by a variety of playful behaviours that are fundamentally relevant for study. Thirdly, these spaces present easy access spaces for material games and other play objects facilitating the study on those objects in a variety of manners. Finally, it is a known public space that people may be comfortable in.

While designing, upkeeping and coordinating research in such a space requires a substantial level of labour, taken together it appears to have been worth it for Tampere University. The space has been academically published on several times, and the options and benefits are far from being fully leveraged. This work has aimed to unpack some of the unique ways the space has been used and to describe certain tensions, both useful and problematic.

There are also promising ways this kind of space could be leveraged for other diverse types of research. Firstly, scholars can use these spaces as locations to conduct close readings of video games, a common technique in game studies (De Angeli & O'Neill, 2020). Secondly, these spaces could host research through design projects (Zimmerman et al., 2010). These spaces may be ideal for such work, as they have an audience experienced with games, who are primed to participate, and the space has an easeful ability to track behaviour and thus is a promising mixture for an interactive design process to occur with that public.

Oasis research group is also a unique pedagogical program that demonstrates the value this kind of space can provide for teaching diverse approaches to games research. This praxis-based pedagogy was heavily reliant on the benefits of a multi-use game space as a rich supportive structure for conducting a variety of projects.

In this way, third spaces hosting games offer practical contributions to game scholars as a community of practice. As with any diverse groups, scholars have different goals, methods and needs for research. These types of multi-use spaces are a practical example of a tool for how diverse scholars can be benefited by a single investment by a university or research group.

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